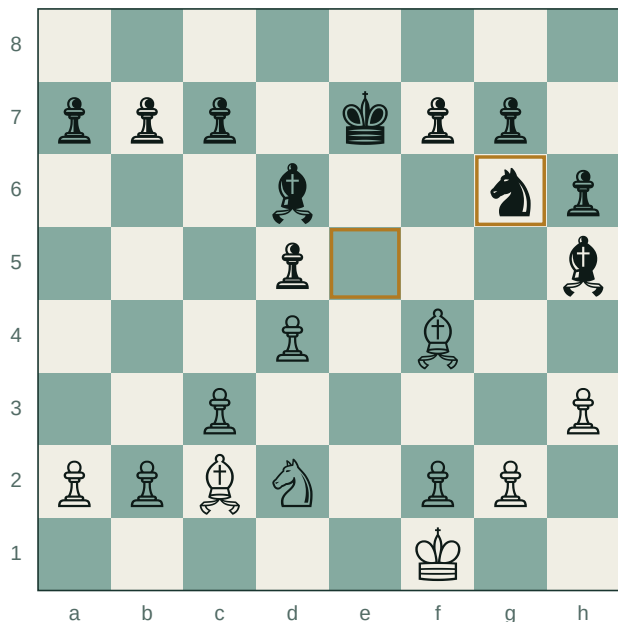


Trapping a piece: White, move 24

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 23...Ng6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24. Bxd6+ Kxd6 25. g4 Nf4 26. gxh5

24.Bxd6+ Check restricts Black to 7 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on d6. Recorded reply: **24...Kxd6**.

25.g4 The pawn moves from g2 to g4. Recorded reply: **25...Nf4**.

26.gxh5 The pawn captures the bishop on h5.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e7. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h5. Check for tactical protection.